PORT CHICAGO · 17 JULY 1944

The Last Wave from Port Chicago · the 2026 edition, and the lost film

WHAT THIS IS

On the night of 17 July 1944 the Port Chicago Naval Magazine, on the shore of Suisun Bay in California, blew up and killed about 320 men. Peter Vogel spent some thirty years arguing that it was no accident. His book, *The Last Wave from Port Chicago*, is being prepared in a 2026 edition.

Around the year 2000 a brief film of the explosion itself could be watched on Vogel's website. No copy has been found since. This page sets out what is known about it, where each piece comes from, and what is still open.

a book in preparation · a film being searched for · every claim sourced



An illustration, not the seismogram: the two shocks recorded about seven seconds apart.

THE PAGE LAYOUT BELOW IS STANDARD ON EVERY GYR-O SITE

– What is this site?

The home of the 2026 edition of *The Last Wave from Port Chicago*, and of the search for a lost film of the 1944 explosion. The book is Peter Vogel's research, which I assembled into a Kindle edition in 2025 and am now preparing again, with a new introduction and corrections.

Every statement here carries a small numeral that opens its source in the middle column, and anything not yet settled is said to be unsettled. The detail, and the list of checks made against the published record, is in column C.

– What happened at Port Chicago?

On 17 July 1944, at about 10:18 at night, the Port Chicago Naval Magazine blew up while two cargo ships were being loaded with munitions. About 320 men were killed instantly, nearly two-thirds of them African American sailors of the loading crews; the dead also included merchant seamen and the Navy gun crews aboard the ships, a Marine sentry and civilian employees[1].

The Liberty ship *E.A. Bryan*, at the center of the blast, was destroyed outright. The Victory ship *Quinault Victory* was lifted out of the water and came down upside down about 500 feet away[3]. The Navy photographed the damage the next day, and those photographs are public[4].

The town of Port Chicago, named in 1931 after the city in Illinois, was later bought by the federal government and demolished; a Port Chicago Highway is still on the map[2].

– Who was Peter Vogel?

The researcher who spent some thirty years arguing that the explosion was not an accident. His article "The Last Wave from Port Chicago" appeared in the journal *The Black Scholar* in 1982[6], and the radio host Dave Emory interviewed him in 1999, 2004 and 2007[7][8][9].

Around 2001 he put a book of the same name on his website, sixteen chapters and four appendices, 429 pages in all, as PDF files. It looked ready for the printer but was never published as a book. He closed his website in December 2018, and nothing has been heard from him publicly since.

– What is the Gadget document?

The document Vogel's whole project started from: "History of 10,000 Ton Gadget", a one-page table whose last row reads "Ball of fire mushroom out at 18,000 ft in typical Port Chicago

fashion". Its eleven numbered rows follow an explosion from detonation to the damage area, with columns of times, distances, pressures and temperatures.

Vogel found it in 1980, in an envelope at the bottom of a cardboard box of old photographic papers he bought for 25 cents at the rummage sale of a Santa Fe church, and kept the receipt[8]. The box had belonged to Paul Masters, a photo technician at wartime Los Alamos. At wartime Los Alamos, "gadget" was the word used in place of "bomb"[5]. Vogel called it the most detailed mathematical model of an atom bomb explosion the public was ever likely to see, and then left it out of his own book.

The 2026 edition prints it in full on the page after the new introduction.

– What is the lost film?

A brief clip of the explosion itself, at night, as it happened. I watched it on Vogel's website around 2000 and downloaded a copy around 2001. No copy has been found since: not among the research files that came with Vogel's book, and not in any archive searched so far.

The Navy is said to have denied the film's authenticity; where and when is still being traced, because a denial of authenticity means somebody was shown something. A 2007 description of one of Emory's interviews mentions "a film, purporting to be a simulation of the Port Chicago explosion"[9]. Whether that is the same film is not yet known.

Obtaining a copy of the film would powerfully refute the untruth that the explosion was an accident.

– What would the film prove, and what would it not?

It would prove that a film of the explosion existed. On its own it would not prove what kind of explosion it was.

Two questions are kept apart on this page. The first is a question of record: did the film exist, who held it, and where did it go? The second is a question of interpretation: was the explosion nuclear? The search for the film serves the first. A blinding flash and a rising column would be seen either way. What could bear on the second is measurement: the film's frame rate and the camera's distance, the growth of the fireball, and the two shocks about seven seconds apart that the seismograph recorded.

A third question sits between them: was the explosion anticipated? A clip of the blast itself, at night, as it happened, means a camera was already running and pointed at the pier. If it was there to record the explosion, the explosion was expected, and it was no accident. The answer a skeptic will give is that the Navy may have been filming the loading routinely; Harry V. Martin

raised that possibility himself in 1990. The film's vantage point, the time it starts, and whether other loading footage exists from the same camera would settle which.

– What changes in the 2026 edition?

A new introduction, the Gadget document printed in full, and corrections to the 2025 text. The corrections found so far:

- the time of the explosion: 10:17 in the text, 22:18:47 Pacific War Time by the seismograph;
- the date of the explosion, given once as 17 October: it was 17 July;
- the year I saw the film (2000) against the year I downloaded it (2001);
- the dead were not all Navy men: merchant seamen and civilian employees died too[1];
- a statement that Dave Emory's 1999 broadcasts mention the film, which they do not.

Column C lists every check made against the published record, including the ones still open.

– Have you seen the film, or do you have a copy?

Please write to me: suppressed.atomic.secrets@gmail.com. Anyone who downloaded files from portchicago.org, or from Peter Vogel's later websites, between about 1999 and 2018 may hold a copy without knowing it. A file name, a date, or a memory of where you saw it is worth sending.

– When will the 2026 edition be published?

When the introduction and the corrections are finished; no date is set yet. It will be a Kindle book, like the 2025 edition, and this page will say when it is out.

B SOURCES ✓

HOW TO READ A CARD

Every card below reads the same way, top to bottom. Parts 4 and 5 are the ones a bare footnote never gives you.

1. **Number and kind** — what sort of thing it is
2. **Title** — what it is called
3. **Provenance** — who made it, when, under what license
4. **Preview** — what you would find if you went there
5. **Why it is cited** — what it is doing on this page
6. **The link** — last, and only last

INTERNAL LINKS

The two most recent content changes, and the record behind them.

28 October 2026 — the lost film, and what it would and would not prove

What is known about the clip seen around 2000, the only outside mention of a film found so far, and why the record question is kept apart from the question of what kind of explosion it was.

28 October 2026 — checks made against the published record

Every place where the 2025 text or the story as told differs from a published source, settled or still open, in column C.

Chronicle — what has been happening, and why

The record of this site and of the 2026 edition, newest first, with what is still unresolved.

EXTERNAL LINKS

Every reference to some other website, previewed. The link is always the last line — read the card first and decide whether you need the round-trip distraction of visiting the original at all.

1 OFFICIAL HISTORY · THE EVENT

Port Chicago Naval Magazine Explosion

Naval History and Heritage Command, U.S. Navy

The Navy's own account: about 320 killed instantly, among them Navy men of the loading details, a Marine sentry, the Navy Armed Guard and merchant crews of the ships, and civilian employees; nearly two-thirds African American sailors; only 51 remains identifiable. The *E.A. Bryan* destroyed with most of the pier; the *Quinault Victory* blown into large pieces; a Coast Guard fire barge sunk with its five-man crew.

Why it is cited: for the death toll, who the dead were, and what happened to the ships, in the Navy's own words.

→ history.navy.mil · Port Chicago Naval Magazine Explosion

2 REFERENCE · THE TOWN

Port Chicago, California

Wikipedia

The town on the southern shore of Suisun Bay, called Bay Point until 1931, when a local business leader, Walter Van Winkle, had it renamed after Chicago, Illinois. The federal government bought all its property in 1968 to clear a safety zone around the naval weapons station's docks; the post office closed in 1969.

Why it is cited: for the town's name, where it was, and how it came to be demolished.

→ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Port_Chicago,_California

3 REFERENCE · THE SHIP

SS Quinault Victory

Wikipedia

The Victory ship berthed at the pier that night, with a crew of 36 merchant seamen and 17 Navy Armed Guard. The explosion lifted her out of the water; she landed about 500 feet away, upside down and facing the other way. Railcars of bombs and 5-inch projectiles were waiting to be loaded into her.

Why it is cited: for what became of the second ship, and how far it was thrown.

→ en.wikipedia.org/wiki/SS_Quinault_Victory

4 PHOTOGRAPH · PUBLIC DOMAIN

NH 96822: the pier, the morning after

Mare Island Navy Yard · Naval History and Heritage Command · public domain

Looking north from magazine BM-138 at the wrecked pier, with the remains of a ship off its tip; railway cars with crushed roofs, a damaged car, a crane, and a Marine sentry in the foreground. One of a set of six photographs of the damage.

Why it is cited: to show that the Navy's own photographs of the damage are public, and where to see them.

→ ibiblio.org · HyperWar · NH 96822

5 HISTORY · THE WORD

The Gadget

Los Alamos National Laboratory, National Security Research Center

How "gadget" came to stand for "bomb" at Los Alamos: Oppenheimer suggested it for security, and the word was already in common use for experimental devices. The Trinity device, tested in New Mexico on 16 July 1945, was "the Gadget".

Why it is cited: for what the word in the Gadget document's title meant at Los Alamos in wartime.

→ discover.lanl.gov · The Gadget

6 CITATION · THE 1982 ARTICLE

Do Black Lives Matter at Port Chicago?

Spitfire List (Dave Emory)

A post that cites Vogel's article as "The Last Wave from Port Chicago", *The Black Scholar*, 1982, with a reader giving the issue as volume 13, numbers 2–3, Spring 1982, the issue that also carries Robert L. Allen's "The Port Chicago Disaster and Its Aftermath".

Why it is cited: for the journal, year and issue of Vogel's article. The journal's own page could not be read for this site, so it is cited through this citation.

→ spitfirelist.com · Do Black Lives Matter at Port Chicago?

7 RADIO · 1999

For The Record #163: Interview with Peter Vogel, update on Port Chicago

Dave Emory · recorded 1 August 1999

Two half-hour segments, close in content to Emory's earlier interview, FTR #129. The page gives a description but no audio links.

Why it is cited: as one of Emory's interviews with Vogel, and as one that does not mention the film.

→ spitfirelist.com · FTR #163

8 RADIO · 2004

For The Record #444: Interview with Peter Vogel

Dave Emory · recorded 1 February 2004, posted 19 February 2004

The description names a document, "History of 10,000-Ton Gadget", with Joseph O. Hirschfelder and William G. Penney as its authors, which Vogel picked up at a church rummage sale. Both sides of the recording are linked as MP3 files.

Why it is cited: for the rummage sale, and for the document's title, which agrees with the document itself: "Ton".

→ spitfirelist.com · FTR #444

9 RADIO · 2007

For The Record #605: Interview with Dean McLeod and Peter Vogel about Port Chicago

Dave Emory · recorded 5 August 2007

Vogel together with Dean McLeod, author of *Images of America: Port Chicago*. The description lists among Vogel's discoveries "a film, purporting to be a simulation of the Port Chicago explosion", used with the destruction to support relocating the town's residents. Both sides are linked as MP3 files.

Why it is cited: as the only outside mention of a film found so far. What Vogel says about it on the recording has not yet been checked.

→ spitfirelist.com · FTR #605

10 BOOK · 2022

American Nuclear Deception: Why “the Port Chicago experiment” must be investigated

Daisy B. Herndon · The Port Chicago Witness · 29 August 2022 · 443 pages as an ebook

The one book-length work on the subject since Vogel, by the only person who has said she worked with him. It argues that the explosion was a nuclear event tied to the Manhattan Project, and discusses Roosevelt’s part in the decision to build the bomb.

Why it is cited: as the principal work after Vogel’s, and as the source of the argument that Roosevelt was a witness, checked in column C.

→ everand.com · American Nuclear Deception

11 RECORD · THE PRESIDENT’S WHEREABOUTS

FDR: Day by Day, 18 July 1944

Franklin D. Roosevelt Presidential Library

The day’s log: the President’s train parked on a siding at Fairbanks, Arizona, to charge its batteries, then on through Tucson and a 30-minute stop at Yuma to San Diego, by the old San Diego and Arizona Eastern line.

Why it is cited: for where Roosevelt was the day after the explosion. The entry for 17 July could not be read for this site.

→ fdrlibrary.marist.edu · 18 July 1944

12 HISTORY · THE COPYING MACHINE

Xerography: ASME landmark #88

American Society of Mechanical Engineers

Chester Carlson first made a xerographic copy in 1938; Haloid showed the process publicly in 1948 and brought out its first machine, the Model A, in 1949; the 914 office copier followed in 1959.

Why it is cited: to date the first photocopiers, against the story that the Gadget document was found on the platen of an early copier at wartime Los Alamos.

→ asme.org · landmark #88

C HOW IT WORKS (DETAILS) ✓

Prior know-how is assumed here, and the items become more “technical” toward the bottom.

The record so far, in order

- **1931.** Bay Point is renamed Port Chicago[2].
- **17 July 1944, 22:18:47.** The magazine explodes; two shocks about seven seconds apart are recorded. About 320 killed[1].
- **18 July 1944.** The Navy photographs and films the damage[4]. That next-day footage, Naval Photographic Center film #5193, is public, and is not the film this page is about.
- **16 July 1945.** The Trinity test, the first acknowledged atomic explosion[5].
- **1968–69.** The town is bought and demolished[2].
- **Autumn 1944.** Paul Masters, a photo technician, takes a copy of the Gadget document out of Los Alamos.
- **1980.** Vogel finds it at a Santa Fe church rummage sale[8]; on 27 August he photographs Edward Teller reading it at Los Alamos.
- **1982.** Vogel’s article in *The Black Scholar*[6].
- **1999.** Emory’s first interviews with Vogel[7].
- **About 2000–01.** Vogel posts his book as PDF files; the film can be watched on his site.
- **About 2001.** I download a copy of the film; it has not been found since.
- **2004, 2007.** Emory interviews Vogel again[8][9].
- **December 2018.** Vogel closes his website.
- **2022.** Daisy Herndon’s *American Nuclear Deception*[10].
- **20 July 2025.** *The Last Wave from Port Chicago: 2025 Edition*, a Print Replica Kindle book, Peter Vogel author, Walter Wilkinson editor.
- **2026.** The new edition in preparation, and this site.

Two questions, kept apart

The question of record, whether the film existed and where it went, is answered by documents: catalog entries, transfer records, correspondence, captured copies of web pages. The question of interpretation, whether the explosion was nuclear, is answered, if at all, by measurement. They

are kept apart because evidence for the first is easily read as evidence for the second, and because an archivist asked an inventory question gives an inventory answer.

The search for the film

A 1944 Navy film would have been shot on cellulose nitrate stock, which is flammable and decays; archives keep nitrate in separate vaults, with their own inventories and handling records, so a nitrate original, or its transfer to safety film or videotape, leaves a paper trail. The places being asked are the National Archives' Motion Picture Branch, across record groups 428, 24, 74, 77 and 156, and the Naval History and Heritage Command. The questions are inventory questions only: what is held, what was photographed on the night of 17 July as distinct from the morning after, and what was copied for whom in the 1990s.

Vogel's own sites are being searched through the Wayback Machine's capture index, for the film's file name, its caption and its source credit rather than the film itself. A video streamed in 2000 was usually reached through a small pointer file, and the pointer, if captured, names the stream.

Checks made against the published record

Each place where the 2025 text, or the story as it is usually told, differs from a published source. A difference is listed here when it is found, not when it is resolved.

As told	The published record	Status
The dead were all Navy men (2025 text)	Merchant seamen, Armed Guard, a Marine sentry and civilian employees died too [1]	Corrected in 2026
There were no civilian casualties	The Navy lists civilian employees among the dead, and merchant seamen are civilians [1]	Corrected in 2026
321 dead	About 320 killed instantly, by the Navy's count [1]	Open: which count, and what each includes
10:17 pm (2025 text)	22:18:47–22:18:54.5 Pacific War Time by the seismograph	Corrected in 2026
The second ship was thrown a mile and floated upside down with a broken keel	Lifted out of the water and landed about 500 feet away, upside down [3];	Open: the photograph should settle it

As told	The published record	Status
	the Navy says blown into large pieces that sank[1]	
Port Chicago was named as a joke	Named in 1931 after Chicago, Illinois, at a local business leader's suggestion[2]	Settled
Vogel's article appeared in 1981 (2025 Preface) or 1983	Cited as Spring 1982, volume 13, numbers 2–3[6]; the 2025 edition itself also says 1982 elsewhere	Open: the issue itself settles it
"The History of the 10,000 Pound Gadget"	The document's own heading, and Emory's page, read "Ton"[8]	Settled: Ton
The last row gives 15,000 feet, "a la Port Chicago"	Row 11 reads "Ball of fire mushroom out at 18,000 ft in typical Port Chicago fashion"	Settled from the document
17 October 1944 (2025 Preface)	17 July 1944[1]	Corrected in 2026
The document was found on the platen of an early photocopier at wartime Los Alamos	No xerographic copier existed before 1949[12]; a wartime copier would have been photographic	Open: which machine, and whose story
Emory's broadcasts mention the film (2025 text)	The 1999 programs do not[7]; the 2007 program's description mentions a "simulation" film[9]	Corrected in 2026; the 2007 recording to be heard
Roosevelt was probably an eyewitness	His train was in southern Arizona on 18 July 1944[11]; the entry for 17 July is not yet read	Open: her evidence needs reading[10]

Technical Colophon

Format	GYR-O Pages, Format Definition 0.27
File	one HTML page and a chronicle
Scripts	JavaScript, shared with every GYR-O site; the page reads without them
Fonts	Source Serif 4, IBM Plex Mono
Hosting	GitHub Pages
TLS	Let's Encrypt

Domain	port-chicago.online, DNS at Cloudflare
Built and checked	Claude; Playwright
Collected	nothing: no cookies, no analytics
License	code MIT · words reserved
Last change	28 October 2026

The Last Wave from Port Chicago · the 2026 edition

Walter Wilkinson · Worland · Washakie County · Wyoming · **5Ws**

No analytics, no trackers, no cookies. This page sets nothing and stores nothing for its readers.

GYR-O = **G**reen · **Y**ellow · **R**ed · and sometimes **O**range

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